

US Presidents

Since the office was created in 1789, there have been 43 presidents of the United States, all men. To be eligible, a person has to be at least 35 years old and born either in the USA, or overseas to US-citizen parents. As well as being Head of State, the president is Commander-in-Chief of the country's armed forces.



GEORGE WASHINGTON

1789–97
Led army against the British in the American Revolution, then became the first president. Unanimously elected.



JOHN ADAMS
1797–1801

Helped draft the Declaration of Independence. Established the naval department, so he is remembered as the "Father of the Navy".



WILLIAM HENRY HARRISON
1841

The first president to die in office. He died of pneumonia only a month after he became president.



JOHN TYLER
1841–45

Vice-president who took the presidency on the death of William Henry Harrison, making him the first president to serve without being elected to office.



JAMES K POLK
1845–49

Greatly expanded the territory of the USA, adding Texas, Wisconsin, and Iowa as states, and taking over land in the west that would become New Mexico and California.



ZACHARY TAYLOR
1849–50

Successful military general who commanded US forces in the war against Mexico (1846–48). Died of cholera a year after taking office.



MILLARD FILLMORE
1850–53

Tried to make a compromise between the anti-slavery states and the slave-owning states in the south, but the peace was short-lived.



FRANKLIN PIERCE
1853–57

Allowed new states to decide for themselves whether to allow slavery, which angered many and edged the USA ever closer to civil war.



CHESTER A ARTHUR
1881–85

Brought in a law that meant that civil servants were hired purely for their ability rather than because of their political connections.



GROVER CLEVELAND
1885–89; 1893–97

The only president ever to serve two non-consecutive terms – he lost an election, then was voted back in again four years later.



BENJAMIN HARRISON
1889–93

Grandson of President William Harrison, during his term the country expanded and six new states were admitted to the Union.



WILLIAM MCKINLEY
1897–1901

Oversaw expansion of US territories, including Hawaii and Puerto Rico. Six months into his second term, he was assassinated.



THEODORE ROOSEVELT
1901–09

The youngest person to become president, at 42. Won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1906 for negotiating peace between Russia and Japan.



WILLIAM H TAFT
1909–13

A lawyer by profession, he set up the postal savings bank and passed a law allowing states to collect income tax.



DWIGHT D EISENHOWER
1953–61

Led the Allied armed forces in World War II. During his two terms of office, the US economy thrived.



JOHN F KENNEDY
1961–63

His work to reform civil rights and promote racial equality was cut short when he was shot dead in Texas.



LYNDON B JOHNSON
1963–69

Brought in the Civil Rights Act, but faced opposition for sending more troops into the war in Vietnam.



RICHARD NIXON
1969–74

Ended the Vietnam War and improved relations with the USSR. His term ended in disgrace after political corruption was uncovered.



GERALD FORD
1974–77

Unexpectedly became vice-president, then president, during an era of scandals. His honesty helped restore the image of the presidency.



JIMMY CARTER
1977–81

President during a difficult period for the USA, both at home and abroad. After his term in office, he became a respected statesman.